

Denver → Yellowstone — RV Road Trip

9–15 July 2026 | Mr Mark Williams, party of 4 | Road Bear Class C 29–31' | Booking CXF847765-1
Arrive DEN Thu 9 Jul 11:00 · depart DEN Wed 15 Jul 14:05 · pickup & drop-off: Road Bear, 6586 Brighton Blvd, Commerce City · +1 720-570-1100.

***This version:** cowboy gear on the way up, two Yellowstone bases (Fishing Bridge then Madison), the Cody Nite Rodeo on Sunday, and a relaxed three-leg drive home reaching the Fort Collins lake KOA early. Driving times every day.*

Route at a glance

Date	Overnight	Driving (approx.)	Highlights
Thu 9 Jul	Casper, WY	4h30 / 265 mi	Land, pickup, big shop, drive north
Fri 10 Jul	Fishing Bridge RV	~5h50 / 293 mi	Cowboy store , hot springs, into the park
Sat 11 Jul	Madison (geyser side)	~2h25 / 96 mi	Dawn wildlife, geysers, then Madison
Sun 12 Jul	Cody, WY	~3h30 / 130 mi	Canyon & Hayden, then rodeo 8 PM
Mon 13 Jul	Casper, WY	3h55 / 214 mi	Easy drive south (optional soak)
Tue 14 Jul	Fort Collins, CO	3h30 / 230 mi	Arrive early — enjoy the lake!
Wed 15 Jul	Fly home	1h00 / 50 mi	Drop by 10:30, fly 14:05

The drive home is now three short legs instead of one marathon — you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon on Tuesday. Total RV driving ~26 hours / ~1,310 mi of the 1,400 included.

Where you're staying

Night	RV park	Where & how to book
Thu 9 Jul	Casper KOA Journey	Bar Nunn, off I-25 — book direct , +1 307-577-1664
Fri 10 Jul	Fishing Bridge RV Park	Inside Yellowstone — Yellowstone NP Lodges, +1 307-344-7311
Sat 11 Jul	Madison Campground	Inside Yellowstone — Yellowstone NP Lodges (sells out first)
Sun 12 Jul	Cody / Yellowstone East KOA	Cody — free rodeo shuttle ; book direct, +1 307-587-2369
Mon 13 Jul	Casper KOA Journey	Bar Nunn, off I-25 — book direct , +1 307-577-1664
Tue 14 Jul	Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA	Fort Collins — book direct , +1 970-484-9880

Four nights outside the park you book yourself (Casper ×2, Cody, Fort Collins — all full hook-ups). The two Yellowstone nights (Fishing Bridge, then Madison) are booked through Yellowstone National Park Lodges — Madison sells out first, so grab it the instant your dates are bookable.

Book these now (priority order)

- **Road Bear pickup appointment** — call +1 720-570-1100 to lock your 9 Jul slot (1:00–4:00 PM window).

- **Fishing Bridge RV Park × 1 night** (Fri 10 Jul) — the only full-hookup site in the park, hard-sided rigs only. Yellowstone NP Lodges: +1 307-344-7311 / 866-439-7375. Combined length ~31 ft.
- **Madison Campground × 1 night** (Sat 11 Jul) — the **first Yellowstone campground to sell out each summer night**, so book it the instant your dates are bookable. Same line: +1 307-344-7311. Dry camping, dump station, 31 ft fine. **Most urgent.**
- **Cody / Yellowstone East KOA × 1 night (Sun 12 Jul)** — free nightly shuttle to the Cody Nite Rodeo (departs 7 PM), two pools, a hot tub and free pancakes. Reserve at koa.com/campgrounds/cody or +1 307-587-2369 (online booking is sometimes off — call to confirm).
- **Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12 Jul, 8:00 PM, Stampede Park)** — codystampederodeo.com (~\$25–79/seat) or at the gate; gates 7:00 PM.
- **Casper KOA Journey × 2 nights** (Thu 9 Jul AND Mon 13 Jul) — book direct, +1 307-577-1664 (pool, dog park, just off I-25).
- **Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA × 1** (Tue 14 Jul) — book direct, +1 970-484-9880.
- **Park entrance pass** — on Recreation.gov. \$35/vehicle (7 days), OR the \$250 Non-Resident Annual Pass if travelling as UK residents (covers all 4 + every park for a year). **Cowboy store:** Lou Taubert, Casper (Fri 10 Jul, opens 10:00) — no booking.

Day by day (with departure & arrival times)

Day 1 — Thu 9 July: Land Denver → Casper

Driving ~4h30 / 265 mi (after pickup & shop)

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Commerce City → Casper (I-25 N)	15:30	20:15	4h30*	265

11:00 Land at DEN. **11:45** bags, then Road Bear shuttle / Uber to the branch (~20 min) — luggage only, not the RV yet.

13:00 Pickup appointment, 6586 Brighton Blvd. Walkthrough 60–90 min, paperwork, deposit (balance \$4,085.03 due; \$300 already paid on the Amex).

~14:30 Big shop — Walmart Supercenter, 5990 Dahlia St (5 min from the branch): a week of water, food, snacks, coffee, sealed/zip bags for bear-safe storage, sunscreen, bug spray, torches.

15:30 North on I-25. ***~17:45** fuel & leg-stretch at Wheatland (~140 mi). Summer light to ~20:45.

~20:15 arrive Casper; cook in or grab dinner.

Fuel: Tank starts full. Splash-and-dash at Wheatland; top up in Casper.

Overnight: Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

Day 2 — Fri 10 July: Casper → Yellowstone — cowboy gear & hot springs

Driving ~5h50 / 293 mi — the big scenic transit day

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Casper → Thermopolis	11:45	14:00	2h15	130
Thermopolis → Cody	15:30	17:10	1h40	84
Cody → Fishing Bridge	17:30	19:25	1h55	79

10:00 Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters, 125 E 2nd St, Casper (opens 10:00) — six floors of Western wear; cowboy hats & boots for the family. ~1h30.

11:45 Depart Casper; Wind River Canyon en route (2,500-ft walls).

14:00 Thermopolis — lunch + a soak at Hot Springs State Park (free State Bath House, ~20-min soak). Wyoming Dinosaur Center next door for the kids.

15:30 Depart; quick fuel in Cody (~17:10), then the scenic Wapiti Valley and over Sylvan Pass (8,500 ft — steady).

~19:25 arrive Fishing Bridge (light until ~21:00). Full hookups, showers, laundry. Hard-sided rigs only here — store all food inside.

Fuel: FILL IN CODY before the park — last good-value fuel; in-park gas is pricier.

Overnight: Fishing Bridge RV Park (1 night)

Day 3 — Sat 11 July: Dawn Hayden Valley, then Geysers to Madison

Driving ~2h25 / ~96 mi — a dawn wildlife drive, then geysers to the river

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Fishing Bridge → Hayden Valley (dawn)	05:15	05:40	0h25	16
Hayden Valley → Fishing Bridge	08:00	08:25	0h25	16
Fishing Bridge → West Thumb	09:00	09:20	0h20	21
West Thumb → Old Faithful	09:30	10:05	0h35	19
Old Faithful → Midway (Grand Prismatic)			0h15	8
Midway → Madison Campground	15:30	15:55	0h25	16

~05:15 Dawn wildlife drive — Hayden Valley (25 min north): first light is the best wildlife window in the park — big bison herds, elk, and a good chance of grizzly or wolf at distance. Bring binoculars; stay 100 yds from bears/wolves. Back for breakfast ~08:30.

Before heading west: fill the fresh-water tank and use the dump station at Fishing Bridge (Madison has no hook-ups).

West Thumb Geyser Basin — colourful hot springs right on the lakeshore; a quick warm-up boardwalk.

Old Faithful & Upper Geyser Basin — check the predicted eruption time, walk the boardwalks (Castle, Grand, Morning Glory Pool) and step inside the historic Old Faithful Inn. Lunch here.

Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring, the largest hot spring in the US (Overlook open; check the NPS app for trail closures). A dip on Firehole Canyon Drive on the way is a fun extra.

~16:00 set up at Madison — a lovely change of scene on the Madison River; bison in the meadows, elk at dusk. Dry camping (generator 8 AM–8 PM; nights are cool at 6,800 ft so no overnight AC needed; no showers — you showered at Fishing Bridge).

Fuel: Fill at the Old Faithful station if low — no fuel at Madison Campground itself.

Overnight: Madison Campground (dry camping), +1 307-344-7311

Day 4 — Sun 12 July: Madison → Cody — Canyon & the Rodeo

Driving ~3h25 / ~125 mi — the canyon is right on your way out

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Madison → Canyon (via Norris)	08:00	09:00	1h00	26
Canyon → Fishing Bridge (via Hayden Valley)	10:45	11:30	0h45	27
Fishing Bridge → East Entrance → Cody	11:45	13:50	1h40	79

Morning: the **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone** — Artist Point and the Lower Falls (an optional Norris Geyser Basin stop en route from Madison).

Late morning: roll south through **Hayden Valley** for wildlife (bison, elk, often grizzly or wolf at distance — stay 100 yds back), past Fishing Bridge and out the East Entrance down the gorgeous Wapiti Valley.

~14:00 **Cody** — the **Buffalo Bill Center of the West** sits on the west side as you arrive (firearms, Plains Indian, art, natural history and Buffalo Bill wings; 2–3h, closes 6 PM) — wear the new hats! Then check in at the KOA on the east edge of town and have a swim.

19:00 hop the KOA's **free rodeo shuttle** (leaves camp at 7:00 sharp — no driving or parking the rig). 20:00 **Cody Nite Rodeo** — ~2 hours of bronc & bull riding, barrel racing and a kids' calf scramble; the shuttle brings you back.

Fuel: Fill up in Cody (last good-value fuel) when you arrive.

Overnight: Cody / Yellowstone East KOA, +1 307-587-2369 (free rodeo shuttle)

Day 5 — Mon 13 July: Cody → Casper

Driving ~3h55 / 214 mi — a relaxed half-day

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Cody → Thermopolis	09:30	11:10	1h40	84
Thermopolis → Casper	12:30	14:45	2h15	130

Easy morning in Cody — finish the Buffalo Bill Center, or browse Sheridan Ave for more Western bits.

11:10 **Thermopolis** — a second soak at Hot Springs State Park and lunch, if you fancy it.

~14:45 **Casper** — arrive mid-afternoon with time for the KOA pool and an easy evening before the last stretch.

Fuel: Fill in Cody, again in Casper.

Overnight: Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

Day 6 — Tue 14 July: Casper → Fort Collins (early finish!)

Driving ~3h30 / 230 mi — on the lake by early afternoon

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Casper → Fort Collins (I-25 S)	09:00	12:45	3h30	230

09:00 An unhurried start; drive south on I-25 into Colorado.

~12:45 Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA — check in early and make the most of it: paddle boats and fishing on the lake, mini-golf, the pool and the jumping pillow.

Evening: Old Town Fort Collins (the model for Disney's Main Street USA) and the breweries for a relaxed last dinner.

Fuel: Top off near Fort Collins so tomorrow morning is just a quick fill to full.

Overnight: Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA, +1 970-484-9880 (on the lake)

Day 7 — Wed 15 July: Drop the RV → fly home

Driving ~1h00 / 50 mi

Today's drive

Leg	Depart	Arrive	Drive	Miles
Fort Collins → Road Bear branch	07:30	08:30	1h00	50

07:30 Depart; top the tank to FULL near the branch (return full — stations on Brighton Blvd / near I-270).

08:30 arrive 6586 Brighton Blvd. Drop-off window 8:00–10:30 AM. Your booking includes **Drop & Go** (Platinum Plus) — no tank-dumping or final clean, just hand it back (~30–45 min).

~09:30 transfer to DEN (~30 min). Be airside by ~12:00 for the **14:05** flight to Orlando.

Fuel: Return the tank FULL to avoid the refuel fee.

Overnight: Drop-off — Road Bear, Commerce City

Fuel, supplies & numbers

- **The rig:** Ford E-450 Class C — ~8–10 mpg, ~55-gallon tank (≈ 450–500 mi range, less on grades/AC). Refuel near the half-tank mark.
- **Fuel towns:** Wheatland/Douglas, Casper, Thermopolis, **Cody (always before the park)**, plus in-park stations at Fishing Bridge, Canyon, Old Faithful and Grant.
- **Rough fuel cost:** $\sim 1,310 \text{ mi} \div 9 \text{ mpg} \approx 146 \text{ gal} \times \sim \$3.60 \approx \text{\$525}$ for the week.
- **Water & tanks:** full hook-ups at Fishing Bridge (Fri) — dump and fill the fresh tank there before Saturday's move to Madison, which is one dry-camp night (generator + holding tanks).

Item	Estimate
Park entry	\$35/vehicle (7-day) or \$250 non-resident annual pass
Fishing Bridge RV × 1	~\$94 + tax
Madison × 1	~\$38 + tax
Casper × 2, Cody × 1, Fort Collins × 1	~\$45–75/night

Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12)	~\$25–79/seat
Fuel (week)	~\$510
Road Bear balance at pickup	\$4,085.03 (\$300 deposit already paid)

The drive home, mileage & practical notes

- **Why the way home is easy now:** instead of one 444-mile Cody→Fort Collins marathon, the rodeo is on **Sunday** night, you overnight in **Casper** on Monday, and Tuesday is a short ~230-mile run — so you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon with the whole day to enjoy it.
- **Two bases:** Fishing Bridge (Lake/east, full hook-ups) on Friday, then Madison (riverside/west, in geyser country) on Saturday. Madison is dry camping — no power/water/sewer and no showers — so dump and fill water and shower at Fishing Bridge first, and run the generator 8 AM–8 PM (cool nights mean no overnight AC needed). Book Madison the moment you can; it sells out first.
- **Mileage:** ~1,310 mi vs the 1,400 included; over that, Road Bear charges ~\$0.45/mile + tax — so you’ve still ~90 miles of headroom for extra wildlife loops.
- **Bears & food:** store food/scented items inside, carry bear spray on walks, keep your distance from wildlife.
- **Signal:** poor-to-none across the park — download offline Google Maps and the NPS app, and keep this itinerary saved or printed.
- **Day-of entry:** Yellowstone needs no timed-entry reservation — just your pass — but check nps.gov/yell road & closure alerts the morning you go in.

Web links — tap any name

Campgrounds	Stops & sights
Casper KOA Journey	Road Bear RV (depot)
Fishing Bridge RV Park	Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters
Madison Campground	Hot Springs State Park, Thermopolis
Cody / Yellowstone East KOA	Buffalo Bill Center of the West
Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA	Cody Nite Rodeo (tickets)
Yellowstone NP Lodges (camp res.)	Yellowstone NP — geysers / Old Faithful
Walmart Supercenter (big shop)	Yellowstone National Park (official)

Cody Nite Rodeo tickets: codystampederoodeo.com · Yellowstone campground reservations (2026): Yellowstone National Park Lodges, +1 307-344-7311.

Prepared for Mark Williams · distances and times are approximate · confirm campground, rodeo and store availability when booking.